Deshpande earned from his law practice'.[18] At the heart of this enterprise was a belief that Christian missionaries were instrumental in creating a divide between tribal communities and urban Hindus. The Ashram's official history claims, 'The cultural predecessor [agraj] forest dweller [vanvasi] was called adivasi and given a separate identity—the vanvasis were given weapons against their own rule—calling Adivasi this land's original resident and Hindu society as attacking [aakramak] they created the base for creating several nations within the Indian nation—then they gave this fertiliser and water and created a poison fruit tree. In a planned manner they created a conspiracy so that town-dwelling Hindus and forest-dwelling Hindus started seeing each other as enemies instead of as brothers.'[19]

Nehru, Prasad and the Congress Traditionalists: Foreign Missionaries and Independent India's First Conversions Debate (1953–1955)

While ABVKA itself was too small to make it to the national headlines in the 1950s, the manner in which it framed itself locally as a 'Hindu' counter-reaction to foreign missionaries mirrored a much larger debate on the evangelical activities of Christian churches that unfolded in Delhi between Nehru, Rajendra Prasad, the Home Ministry and several Congress chief ministers. Coming soon after the controversy over Rajendra Prasad's decision to attend the installation of idols at the reconstructed Somnath Temple in Gujarat,[20] this controversy reflected yet another episode in the tensions over religion, freedom of expression, the role of the state and a Hindu backlash that animated the ruling Congress.

The debate started with Home Minister K.N. Katju telling Parliament on 15 April 1953 that, while Indians were free to propagate their religion, the new government 'did not want people from outside [missionaries] to come and do that'. Katju flatly declared that 'if they come here for evangelical work, then the sooner they stop it the better'.[21] Five months later, in September 1953, he announced that Nehru's government had already expelled three